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Why Spheres of Exchange?

Author(s): Paul Sillitoe

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NEW YORK STOCK EXCHANGE

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Spheres of exchange, a classic anthropological topic, is briefly reviewed. The concept prompts looking at implied spheres of production. All production is not the same; different arrangements characterize different spheres, as with subsistence goods compared to wealth items. The implications are significant for acephalous political orders that eschew any section of society exercising control over resources or capital needed by others for livelihood, so exerting hegemony over them. Spheres of exchange intimate the disconnection of subsistence from wealth production, effectively inhibiting relations of domination, promoting egalitarian distribution of livelihood resources. The introduction of (all-purpose) money, in the process of historically interrelated colonial, globalizing, and economic development interventions ruptures the insulation of spheres, marking the arrival of capitalist market arrangements and associated antithetical hierarchical rich and poor relations. (Economic anthropology, spheres of exchange, production, acephalous politics)

My experience as an instructor delivering lectures on economic anthropology has confirmed this impression, as curious students regularly ask why some people have spheres of exchange. One increasingly feels obliged to give more explanatory attention to the “why spheres of exchange” question and not expect students to find the answer themselves in the ethnography. Perhaps a formulation offered here might satisfy students’ curiosity.

What are spheres of exchange? They are an arrangement where material objects are assigned to different spheres for transactional purposes. People freely exchange items within the same sphere and readily calculate their comparative values. But things in different spheres are not immediately exchangeable against one another, such that between spheres there is no ready conversion (Bohannon and Dalton 1962:3–7). The question students regularly ask is why do some populations place such restrictions on the exchange of things? That in West Africa one cannot give yams in return for cloth, or in the Solomon Islands taro for turmeric cylinders, is a puzzle. There is no obvious reason why some cultures

should institute such barriers to the transaction of things that might otherwise change hands. This is the key problem addressed here.

The argument focuses on the independent circulation of subsistence items and wealth valuables, as necessary to the constitution of the egalitarian sociopolitical orders in which ethnographers have identified spheres of exchange. The thesis, briefly, is that while all households can produce necessary subsistence consumables, which are not scarce, they cannot produce wealth items at will, which by definition are scarce and which originate either externally or come into being through the process of exchange itself. Consequently, politically ambitious persons cannot seek to control wealth production, either indirectly by stepping up output of subsistence goods to exchange for valuables, or directly by controlling manufacture of valuables. Furthermore, in effectively disconnecting the sphere of subsistence (food, etc.) from the sphere of wealth (valued objects), the spheres of exchange arrangement promotes an egalitarian distribution of livelihood resources for all, inhibiting domination. The introduction of (all-purpose) cash may serve as an externally-produced valuable (particularly in regions remote from the capitalist market), but may also upset sphere arrangements by making items commensurate, linking the previously disconnected levels, which is an aspect of the undermining of the acephalous order (particularly in regions connected to markets).

The actors themselves do not necessarily distinguish these spheres as labeled categories (Bohannan 1955:61). They are a device, used by ethnographers in describing the transactional behavior they observe and possibly comments by individuals to the effect that one should not exchange object X for object Y. People may not apparently be interested in formally identifying spheres or engaging in abstract debates on restrictions on the transaction of certain items against others, being too busy living the political-economy to reflect on it. This article likewise seeks to use the spheres of exchange formulation as a heuristic device to further an understanding of the political economic implications of such limitations on transactions.

SOME ETHNOGRAPHIC BACKGROUND

The ethnography known to me, where authors postulate the existence of spheres of exchange, is predominantly Pacific. The interpretation offered draws heavily on New Guinea, where it has wide applicability and appears to fit some of the African exchange spheres, but this is not to suggest that it has universal applicability to stateless orders. It may be possible elsewhere to produce wealth through individual labor, which may feature in people's subsistence regimes such as livestock wealth among East African pastoralists. Presumably there are other mechanisms that prevent enterprising and ambitious persons seeking some

control that they can convert to political power and undermine the acephalous order. It is conceivable however that the spheres of exchange formulation has wider applicability than the limited body of ethnography to which it has been applied. The Kwakiutl of northwest America, to take a classic body of work that may lend itself to such an interpretation, with the production of valued coppers dependent on the import of raw materials and their manufacture an affair of community interest (as with the carving of valued wooden objects featuring numaym totemic symbols), whereas subsistence activities such as salmon fishing were undertaken by independent households with equal access to necessary resources. A test of the model proposed here, and a search for possible variations on the theme of spheres of exchange and their implications (as suggested by a reader of this article) would demand a review of a wide body of literature on stateless political economies, with a carefully reasoned case for imposing the spheres model on each body of ethnography. This requires a monograph as opposed to a brief article.

A favorite ethnographic example is the Tiv of Nigeria (Bohannan 1955, 1963:248–53; Bohannan and Bohannan 1968:227–37), who have three spheres of exchange (Table 1). One comprises foodstuffs, including yams, grains, vegetables, small livestock, and everyday utensils and tools. A second sphere includes brass rods, cattle, tugudu white cloth, and slaves. The third is rights in “dependent persons,” primarily marriageable female relatives. According to Bohannan and Bohannan (1968:227–28), “In calling these different areas of exchange spheres, we imply that each includes commodities that are not regarded as equivalent to those commodities in other spheres and hence in ordinary situations are not exchangeable. Each sphere is a different universe of objects. A different set of moral values and different behavior are to be found in each sphere.”

However, the ethnography is somewhat contradictory and maybe not the best to introduce the idea of spheres of exchange. It possibly reflects colonial authority disruption some decades before fieldwork, introducing money and prohibiting certain marriage exchanges (Bloch and Parry 1989:12–16; Hart 2005:164).¹ Bohannan (1963:249) reports that the second sphere “was tightly sealed off from the subsistence-goods sphere . . . no one, save in the depths of extremity, ever paid brass rods for domestic goods.” Yet there are also “conversions” between spheres, ambitious men seeking “to convert food into prestige items; to convert prestige items into dependents—wives and children” (Bohannan 1955:64).² The moral of the system is to transact within spheres. Tiv frown upon transacting higher sphere objects for lower ones, such as brass rods

TABLE 1
SOME SPHERES OF EXCHANGE

	<i>SPHERE 1</i>	<i>SPHERE 2</i>	<i>SPHERE 3</i>
TIV	Foodstuffs, (staple yams and grains, vegetables, small livestock), everyday utensils and tools	Brass rods, cattle, horses, <i>tugudu</i> white cloth, slaves, medicines and magic-prestige goods	“Dependent persons” (marriageable female kin and children)
TIKOPIA	Foodstuffs, small objects (e.g., arm-rings), and everyday services	Bark-cloth, sennit fiber, pandanus mats, coconut grating stools, bowls, specialist labor, and ritual presentations	Bonito-hooks, turmeric cylinders and canoes presented in ceremonial exchanges
SIANE	Foodstuffs (staple sweet potato, taro, bananas, etc.)	“Luxury commodities,” tobacco, salt, pandan nuts and oil	Seashells (pearl shells, cowries, nassa), ornamental stone axes, dogs’ teeth necklaces, feather headdresses, and pigs presented in ceremonial exchanges

for food, but they talk of those who achieve the reverse as showing “strong heart.” That “converting” down is morally reprehensible in fiercely egalitarian Tiv society is a key to the meaning of spheres of exchange.

Elsewhere in Africa, Barth (1967) describes spheres of exchange among the Fur of Sudan. They have two: one embracing many material goods and featuring the use of money, and the other the exchange of beer for labor. Barth (1967:164) also introduces two other spheres related to social standing: one covering feasts and pilgrimages, and another represented by marriage exchanges. These spheres of exchange are quite different to those described in other ethnographies as money can feature in all material transactions, except for the payment of labor in millet cultivation and house construction, which demands beer, and “the sale of beer is regarded as immoral” (Barth 1967:165). Elsewhere money destroys sphere arrangements—another key to their possible import.

These African accounts of spheres of exchange were not the first. In the Pacific, Firth (1939:340–44) used the idea to order his ethnography of the Tikopia, formalizing in some measure previous accounts of transactions in the region. Before then, on the Trobriand Islands, Firth’s teacher Malinowski (1922) famously distinguished gimwali “trade” from kula “ceremonial exchange,” among other transactions such as laga “purchase” and urigubu “yam exchange.” According to Isaac (2005:17–18), the Trobriand “economy” features three spheres of exchange: subsistence products; prestige goods; and kula wealth. Indeed, the spheres of exchange model expands on the distinction between trade and exchange reported throughout Melanesia, where people use a complex vocabulary to distinguish purchase-like transactions from those where they hand around valuables.

The Tikopia operate three spheres of exchange (Table 1). In the lowest sphere are foodstuffs and everyday assistance; the middle one has bark cloth, sinnet fiber, pandan leaf mats, and wooden bowls; while in the highest sphere are bonito-hooks, turmeric cylinders, and canoes. The objects and services in these three series cannot be completely expressed in terms of one another, since normally they are never brought to the bar of exchange together. It is impossible, for example, to express the value of a bonito-hook in terms of a quantity of food, since such exchange is never made and would be regarded by the Tikopia as fantastic (Firth 1939:340).

Other early accounts that mention spheres of exchange arrangements include Thurnwald (1932) and DuBois (1936). Possibly the renowned economist Keynes (1982) was among the first to conceive of spheres of exchange, as Gregory (1997:242) suggests, when he wrote in the 1920s about multiple “standards of value” in the ancient world. The early Greeks, for example, had three spheres: cows and sheep; corn; and iron or bronze (Keynes 1982:259). Spheres of exchange have subsequently proved a popular device in Pacific, particularly

Melanesian, ethnographic writing. The Kapauku of the New Guinea highlands reportedly have four spheres (Pospisil 1963a:341, 1963b:25), although these confusingly overlap. One sphere covers pork, land, crops, bows, net bags, and salt; another, pork, crops, bows, net bags, and bailer shells; a third consists of labor, crops, and land; and the final one is artefacts.³ The spheres reported for the Siane in the New Guinea highlands are more typical. Salisbury (1962:187–203) distinguishes three “nexuses” (Table 1). The first encompasses everyday foodstuffs; the second, “luxury commodities” such as tobacco, pandan nuts, and salt; and the third, valuables such as seashells and pigs presented in sociopolitical exchanges at marriage and in mortuary rites. Waddell (1972:80–81) identifies two spheres among the Enga of the central highlands: subsistence products and wealth transactions.

The common point in all of these sphere arrangements is that they separate the exchange of subsistence products from the exchange of valued objects. As Salisbury (1962:39–40) comments, they distinguish between “activities concerned with the production of subsistence goods . . . and the complex arrangements for trade and ceremonial exchange.” One sphere covers one domain, encompassing everyday food and utensils, and another sphere the other, whatever the local wealth (be it seashells or brass rods), with various intergradations between them. The question, then, is: why this separation? To answer this question I propose to switch the emphasis from exchange to spheres of production (Gregory 1983:117), as this reveals the stateless significance of such arrangements.

SPHERES OF PRODUCTION

Subsistence

The following argument employs two spheres only, after Waddell (1972). This binary representation is heuristically best to further understanding of these arrangements. While the number of spheres identified by ethnographers range from two to four, I propose that we can think of these as essentially comprising two, as Salisbury (1962) notes: one covering subsistence activities, and the other, wealth transactions. It is possible to interpret further spheres as either transition zones between these, such as Salisbury’s “luxury commodities” among the Siane, or divisions within one or other of the two greater spheres, such as when Bohannan and Bohannan (1968) distinguish the exchange of women in marriage from transactions involving wealth items (while the Tiv subscribed to sister exchange, bridewealth comprising wealth objects featured prominently in marriage arrangements),⁴ or Firth’s (1939) mats and carved wooden objects that also feature in ceremonial transactions such as those that mark marriage. While

the reduction to two principal spheres represents a simplification of some of the ethnography as described and interpreted by the ethnographers, streamlining helps us see the principal issues at stake with sphere arrangements, at least from the perspective of the argument presented here. While additional spheres may reflect the richness of the ethnography, they cloud the central issues as I identify them, the dynamics of exchange being more complicated when we introduce three or four spheres.

The household or domestic (Sahlins 1972) mode of production characterizes the subsistence sphere in these societies. All households have access to sufficient land, labor, and capital adequately to meet their livelihood needs according to their customary expectations, and associated material requirements independently of others. Except for abnormal environmental perturbations, these resources are in adequate supply to meet current subsistence demands, although not necessarily wealth demands. They exhibited affluence, in the substantive sense, so long as populations remained apparently satisfied with their standard of living, traditional wants and values unchanging, and with absence of any idea of capitalistic growth (Sahlins 1972; Bird-David 1992; Kaplan 2000; Sillitoe 2002). There is no opportunity for any group to control access to resources where scarcity is not an issue. Each family produces and consumes what it needs, such that there is no call for any intervening distribution of the necessities of life, which contrasts with a market economy organized by specialized productive units—companies and so on—and specialization by occupation where workers depend on others to supply them with essential goods, and the money-facilitated distribution of these features as a central aspect of economic life and affords a possible opportunity for one section of society to exert some control. The subsistence independence of households is central to these social orders, thwarting any such opportunity.

A further notable point is that where people class consumables as valuables, locating them in higher exchange spheres beyond everyday food, they are not necessary to human material existence. They consider these consumables luxuries, such as pork, salt, choice game, and so on. They survive without them for the greater part of their lives, subsisting largely on a vegetable diet, for instance in the New Guinea Highlands, and consuming meat only once every few months (Sillitoe 1983:228–46). What little exchange occurs between the lower subsistence and higher valuables spheres is not an integral part of their livelihoods; it is neither instituted by the economic system nor essential for survival. Transactions that occur either have a social impetus, as with the exchange of yams on the Trobriands or pork at Highland New Guinea pig festivals, or occur because poor planning, bad luck, or some ecological misfortune make it necessary for a household to purchase an area of crops in another's garden.

Valuables

In contrast to the subsistence sphere, scarcity is a consideration regarding valuables that feature in sociopolitical transactions where persons compete politically for status and influence. Even if the resources needed to meet basic needs are in adequate supply, societies may institute culturally defined scarcities by putting a high value on things that are in limited supply (e.g., gold). To ensure their value and qualify as wealth, such things must be in scarce supply, for if everyone had unlimited access to them, they would no longer be valuable. This is evident in reactions to the inflation in supply of valuables since European incursion into the New Guinea Highlands, particularly of some seashells, which resulted in the devaluation of such wealth as no longer acceptable in transactions. When people transact wealth objects, these objects serve as tokens of sociability and their value derives from their use in sequences of socially and politically sanctioned interaction, which contrasts markedly with capitalist distribution, foremost a materially related economic activity. This distinction between exchange and distribution contrasts social well-being with material well-being. The spheres of exchange model intriguingly mirrors the social exchange and economic exchange dichotomy. Regarding valuables such as brass rods and sea-shells, which have no consumable or utilitarian worth (discounting their rare use for personal decoration), it is easy to accept this socially founded evaluation, for without it they would be valueless. Nonetheless, while from a sociological perspective what people give to each other is immaterial—so long as they exchange something, because it is the act of giving that is socially significant—in actuality they will not accept just anything. Exchange only makes sense if people value the things they transact.⁵

Whatever subsistence regimes may suggest about some people appearing content with their material standard of living, it would be misleading to describe them as affluent, in the sense of being satisfied with what they have. New Guinea Highlanders, for example, can never, to their mind, have too much wealth to transact (Lederman 1986:4), be it pigs, seashells, or today, money.⁶ A similar acquisitiveness seemingly drives them as occurs in capitalist orders where even the affluent, never apparently satisfied with their lot, always want more. Although well supplied with the basic necessities of life, their members consider many consumer goods to be scarce (such as executive cars, designer clothes, antique furniture, and fine art). It appears that societies with identified spheres of exchange do something similar, nominating certain items as desirable wealth (e.g., cowrie shells and cattle), acceptable in sociopolitical exchanges in which persons vie for status (Firth 1939; Salisbury 1962; Sillitoe 1979). But there is a major difference. These people want valuables to give away, not necessarily to consume or hold onto, investing them in social exchange activities. They are not

content with the wealth they have, nor ever could be, apparently enmeshed in systems that require them continually to give away what they receive. While successful capitalists are likewise not content with what they have, they differ starkly in seeking to hoard wealth to themselves, investing it in further economic activity to extend political control and accumulating it to advertise their success and power.

The contrast is marked between hierarchical market orders with rich and poor persons, as measured socially by possession of culturally esteemed scarce things or other assets that carry a monetary value, and egalitarian subsistence orders that are constituted in such a way as to stop anyone becoming rich, accumulating wealth connected with subsistence, and securing some hegemony over others. That is, spheres of exchange feature complex arrangements that hedge around and even obfuscate the production of wealth.

WEALTH PRODUCTION: SOME EXAMPLES

Regarding the manufacture of valued objects in Tikopia, such as bonito-hooks and canoes, Firth (1939) says the raw materials are common and anyone can make them. They demand no special skill; the work on hooks, for instance, largely consists of monotonous grinding, which is not onerous. The only skilled part of the process is to lash the turtle shell barbs to the clam shell shank with hibiscus fiber. It appears that many persons had the skill and available resources to manufacture these valuable objects and could have been making them for their own use, to “purchase” other consumable goods and to enhance their social reputations with generous sociopolitical exchanges. Enigmatically, this is not so. Production is desultory, with hook production presumably keeping pace with the destruction of those in use. Firth perplexedly comments, “I have always thought it remarkable that the Tikopia do not make more bonito-hooks. The question why some sharp individuals do not accumulate a stock for trading purposes and why all men do not put in more labor in the production of them is difficult to answer” (1939:342). Their behavior appears contrary to expectations. With no scarcity of raw materials, with skill and opportunity to make valuable objects, few people bother to do so. There are clearly other forces at work here. Imagine that we all have gold at hand and only bother to dig it up occasionally. Gold would no longer be scarce and so no longer carry high value—in which event, why do Tikopia value bonito-hooks?

Similar oddities are apparent when considering making canoes, the property of small kin groups. These are community events, considerable numbers of persons coming along to help with the work. They receive food and various objects (such as bark-cloth and sennit cord) in return for their assistance, Firth (1939) regarding these as their “wages.” But the men who receive these goods

have contributed many of them to the payment in the first place, so they have, in effect, brought along their own “wages.” Firth (1939:303) says this results from “the concept that to put one’s labor at the command of another is a social service, not merely an economic service.” An arrangement where people not only work as a social service but also bring along their own reward again intimates different priorities to those assumed by capitalist economics. The Tikopia present highly valued canoes on occasion in sociopolitical exchanges but “there is no attempt by any member of the community to build up any stock of canoes” (Firth 1939:249), and a range of social and ritual obligations hedge around their production. Any attempt to calculate the value of canoes in terms of the things transacted during their manufacture is to miss the point that, as things presentable in sociopolitical transactions (such as mortuary payments), they have other than material value, symbolized in the co-operation and transactions that characterize their manufacture. As Firth (1979:185) observes, in a publication forty years after his initial discussion of spheres of exchange, “A Tikopia canoe, requiring the work of skilled craftsmen to build, cannot be equated with any quantity of food Canoes and food lie in different circuits of exchange, and their ‘value’ as products of labor alone is not directly commensurable.”

The social dimension to the manufacture of valued objects is further evident in the New Guinea Highlands, where the circumscribed nature of arrangements illustrates what seems a nonproduction of wealth ethic in their obfuscation of the process. Two objects made locally by Wola speakers, possum-teeth beard pins and bird of paradise headdresses, show the disguising of wealth production through incorporation into transaction. Both objects were produced during exchange, having come slowly into being, and were not produced at one time by one person (Sillitoe 1988:328–34; 357–60). The impression created is of wealth transacted into existence. The beard pins, for example, comprise twenty or so incisor teeth from striped possums, mounted as ornamental pins. Each animal supplies two teeth. Men caught possums infrequently, not setting out to hunt with a view to making ornaments but amassing teeth over time sufficient to make a small pin presentable to someone. The pin would slowly get larger as recipients added more teeth when in their possession, until full sized when paired off with another pin to give an esteemed valuable. Feather headdresses were likewise “made” as exchanged, men hunting irregularly and opportunistically for bird of paradise plumes together with colorful parrots’ feather decoration (Sillitoe 2003), each bird caught only supplying a few of the plumes needed. For instance, the Enameled Bird of Paradise could supply only two iridescent feathers. Similar limited manufacturing arrangements held for the Siane, where necklaces requiring about 200 dogs’ canine teeth made “the quantity of necklaces produced . . . minute” (Salisbury 1962:90–91)

Among the first to document wealth produced in transaction was Malinowski (1922:502–04), who describes how the manufacture of mwali armbands continued as they moved around the kula ring. The Conus shells used for armbands occur in the sea around the Trobriand Islands and people sometimes find suitably fine specimens. But instead of busying themselves making armbands to earn renown, men are likely to hand such shells to others, maybe after doing some work on them, as a return gift in the yam harvest exchange sequence. The recipient may continue to fashion the shell into an armband shape and then pass it on to someone, who may proceed to clean off the accretions on the shell before passing it again to someone who may start to polish the armband. This handing-on-manufacturing can go through several transactions, a final polished shell demanding much work. At some point, someone will start to decorate the armband with beads and smaller shells such as cowries, and the creation of the valuable's myth begins, which can ultimately lead to a fine armband achieving great value. Somewhere along the route of exchange, someone will name it. No one is ever responsible for making an entire article from start to finish, underlining the importance of giving and receiving these items in social contexts, such as the kula, and without any economic connotations in terms of their manufacture or use.

The inability of people to produce those objects they transact that originate elsewhere (perhaps for lacking the necessary raw materials in their region, or knowledge of how to make them, as with seashells in the New Guinea Highlands) represents the ultimate disguise of production. Arriving ready made, they exemplify the position with wealth manufacture generally—that those who transact wealth should not make it. In the Kapauku region, “the structure of this trade may be compared to a chain reaction originating at the coast . . . woti, a large bailer shell, dedege necklaces of a tiny species of cowrie-like shell, pagadau necklaces of small European glass beads, and steel axes and machetes, moved along the trade route, by the ‘chain reaction’ from the coast into the interior” (Pospisil 1963a:337). Some of these rare objects may achieve particularly high value locally and have a rich symbolism associated with them, such as Strathern and Stewart (2000:46 ff.) discuss for the Western Highlands. The restricted supply of things from elsewhere limits their occurrence, and people are not busy producing things to trade on the market, which scarcely exists. In the New Guinea Highlands, they sometimes trade such imports locally, although relatives usually hand them to one another in sociopolitical exchange contexts. They may take on a zigzag movement, sometimes oscillating towards and then away from their source, as their direction is not driven by economic-like demand for material resources (Sillitoe 1978). Once in circulation, these objects may change hands many times in sociopolitical transactions (almost indefinitely, if durable like sea-shells) with no productive input required.

While New Guinea Highlanders may not manufacture imported valuables, they indirectly contribute something productively, making things to exchange and trade for them. In terms of a balance of trade, Highlanders likely partly financed these imports by means of a middleman markup on things as they passed through their hands away from the direction of their source, going up in value as they became increasingly scarce with distance. Beyond this, they would have to export some locally produced things to pull such imports into their region, usually pigs, but also sometimes tobacco, pandan nuts, and valued bird plumes, notably bird of paradise. So pig production is important not only to supplying wealth for local transaction but also wealth to pay for valued items from elsewhere.

The most highly valued and industriously produced, locally made wealth—pigs—further illustrates the circumscribed nature of production (Hide 1981; Sillitoe 2003). First, pigs feed on leftover garden produce, usually on substandard sweet potato tubers, and forage daily for themselves, so are more a by-product of human oriented subsistence activities than directly produced. They usefully turn waste into valuable meat, similar to animals in many farming systems. Second, sows lose condition and weight when they breed, which is a disincentive to men, whose transactional concerns focus on meeting exchange commitments in the present. Also, piglets take some time to reach a valuable size. Consequently, families breed pigs reluctantly, chary of the initial results of a few piglets of little value (several of which are likely to die) at the cost of a skinny and somewhat devalued sow. For them, with exchange obligations to meet, a fat sow is more valuable than a thin one with a few piglets, which will take years to grow large. While men focus on upcoming exchange commitments, this does not imply that they do not think about the future and maneuver their commitments according to anticipated demands to discharge their exchange obligations, particularly the more successful (whereas others seem to leave things to the last minute and panic in meeting their responsibilities). Third, there is the complex relationship between women and men in pig production, men not being responsible for herding the animals they exchange. This creates a key political-economic role for women.

TRANSACTIONING WEALTH INTO EXISTENCE

When men claim pigs to exchange, they must transfer them from the domain of production to that of exchange, commonly by making a payment to their herding partner, who is often their wife. They give their partners wealth to redeem the animals, which these women in turn pass on to a male relative, part of the series of transactions between affines (if a woman receives such a payment from her husband, she will likely pass the wealth to her father or brothers).

Similarly, when a man catches a valuable animal in the forest, it would be undignified for him to present it in a sociopolitical transaction. He will hand it to someone who transfers it to the exchange sphere by giving him some wealth in return, thus gaining the right to transact it. Also, men pay wealth to those who produce for them locally made accoutrements that go with some imported valuables, such as the knitted straps of pearl shells in the Southern Highlands. The valuables exchanged around import wealth are transformation payments of a sort. These transformation payments illustrate “indirect relations of production” (Strathern 1988), with persons transacting wealth into existence.⁷ Such transactions move the object from the realm of the economy and production to the social and political realm of exchange. It is no longer something produced but something exchanged.

The transforming transactions ensure that no one directly produces wealth to use in sociopolitical exchange. Things with production domain connections that find their way into the sociopolitical exchange system, or finance the securing of scarce things from elsewhere for use in it, consequently pass through a transformation first that dissociates their productive links. Those who exchange wealth do not produce it, they transact it into existence. A person must pay wealth to others to convert from the productive to the exchange realm what they are responsible for bringing into existence. The cost of transferring something into the exchange realm is the wealth forgone, which could otherwise have been used in another sociopolitical transaction. The valuable will have been received in a previous exchange, but it is the transformation payment recipient who uses it subsequently in yet another transaction. While it is arguable that persons may still obtain wealth through their productive efforts, albeit second-hand, this would be to misconstrue the ethic. The spheres of exchange may be interpreted as signifying this distinction in behavior between the everyday production domain and that of sociopolitical exchange.

The value of wealth is produced in part socially and in part through individual labor, albeit circumscribed, indicating its combined social and material derivation. Wealth objects carry both a tangible and emotive value. The expectation is that people will receive wealth in the transactions that are central to sociopolitical life, not work to make them. Unlike market exchange, reciprocal transaction does not promote productive activity to gain valued things, but striving through transaction to secure them. The moral is that those who transact valuables should not produce them. In his comparative study, Steiner (1954) hints at the spheres of exchange formulation, talking about keeping three categories of things separate: raw materials and foodstuffs; implements; and “personal treasure.” The spheres of exchange intimate restrictions on the supply of objects that circulate in sociopolitical exchanges, with wealth ideally

accessible only through exchanges, as *vaygu'a* "wealth" items are only obtainable for example in *kula* contexts, thus stimulating transaction.

Valuables are not readily available through production, sphere arrangements serving to suppress connections to this domain. It is not their production that should engage people, but the political activities of transacting with them. Hence the desire for scarce wealth does not impact noticeably on the productive domain. This interpretation is at odds with those that focus on labor, such as Kopytoff (1986:72) who maintains that we find "the cultural construction of separate spheres of exchange" where people cannot readily equate the labor put into different things, such as pots with ritual services or tubers with wives, and so put them in different fields, calculating "value-equivalence by creating several discrete commodity spheres." On the contrary, I argue, spheres direct attention away from labor issues. Although it sometimes seems that valuables spontaneously come into existence, we need to ask where they come from and who makes them, as the origin of wealth is central to understanding exchange institutions.

INALIENABILITY IMPLICATIONS

The separation of production from exchange, its systematic obfuscation even, questions the inalienability of "gifts" argument prominent in the Pacific, for there is often no original source identifiable for such supposedly inalienable rights. The argument is that the gift is imbued with the giver's social identity or person, such that it becomes an inalienable object serving to create and reinforce social relations, whereas alienable "commodities" do not (Gregory 1982; Strathern 1988; Weiner 1992; Godelier 1999). This *persona-inheres-to-objects* idea descends directly from Mauss' (1970) questionable interpretation of some Pacific ethnography stressing the morality of the gift as dependent on obligations of reciprocity and contrasting it with the logic of commodity distribution, with its mechanical exchange of goods impoverishing social relations. It proposes thinking of the things given, like the participants, as persons, and that "inalienable possessions are the hub around which social identities are displayed, fabricated, exaggerated, modified, or diminished" (Weiner (1992:99–100).

In addition to the spheres concept querying the inalienability argument, other aspects of people's behavior in the New Guinea Highlands further belies it in my experience. I have never heard anyone suggest that they associate any identity-presence with valuables, let alone spiritual bonds of the sort postulated by Mauss and others. This is not to deny that the likely obligation on the recipient to respond with something later constitutes an important tie, that it signifies something about their relationship, which is indeed a fundamental aspect of these moral transactions, as Mauss and others rightly stress. Second, the

proposal that things given are inalienable suggests that they could be traced back to their original owner. When I asked men to relate the exchange history of durable wealth, such as pearl-shells, we have never progressed far (Thomas 1991:65 makes a similar point for Fiji). Third, some valuables are physically divisible, such as pork, cosmetic oil, and salt. Some may see the “partible person” symbolized in this division of wealth, but surely not inalienably. Fourth, it is difficult to see people discarding traditional wealth, such as seashells, as readily as Highlanders did following inflation in their supply with the arrival of Europeans, if they had such personal attachments and emotional value. Fifth, there is the widespread use of cash today in exchanges and no one suggests personal identity attaches to a dollar bill or whatever. Changes of this magnitude should have prompted a collective identity crisis—persons no longer able to imbue the things they exchange with the personal attachments argued to be so important.

Durable wealth is collective property that is continually in circulation among persons who have temporary possession of it. In this view, transactable objects belong to society as a whole and are not inalienable possessions associated with certain persons. An analogy in Western culture is sporting trophies, such as championship boxing belts owned by all the clubs comprising the association that controls the competition in which constituent club members compete, and which pass for agreed periods of time into the possession of particular champions, changing hands as new champions emerge. Durable valuables potentially belong to everyone collectively, individuals enjoying temporary possession as they receive them in transactions and hand them to someone else in subsequent transactions. Importantly, no one handling them produces them. If there is any sense of persons’ identities associated with objects, it has to be in an accretionary sense. This can give antique objects that passed through many hands a high value, carrying a heavy sentimental social load, as Malinowski pointed out for kula wealth.

IMPLICATIONS OF SPHERE INSULATION

While valuables hardly relate to subsistence and material well-being, there are some connections, however tenuous and obscure. The wealth has to originate somewhere, comprising tangible objects either produced locally or obtained in return for something produced locally. This bears some relation to subsistence produce used in transactions to obtain certain valuables, such that demand for scarce wealth affects livelihoods. But subsistence domain products do not evidence scarcity, due partly to demand and supply-side restrictions; that is, there is no market, as evidenced by spheres of exchange. In essence, the spheres indicate that people cannot produce everyday things in their livelihoods and

“buy” wealth with them, as these things occupy different spheres. They reflect the insulation of domains from one another. Many valued things arrive ready made, and others came into being through abstruse manufacturing arrangements. What are the political implications of these convoluted connections between wealth production and transaction? The disconnection between subsistence and exchange domains is critical to the tribal political-economy.

Spheres of exchange arrangements cast an intriguing light on the question posed by Marxist analysis, namely how can society prevent a minority from controlling resources and capital, and thereby profit handsomely by exploiting the labor of the dispossessed majority? Marxists are correct to argue that for hierarchical political orders to exist, those with power must have some hold over the livelihoods of others, controlling access to land and/or capital, and opportunities for labor. As Firth (1979:193) puts it succinctly, the central issue in Marx’s analysis is “the identification of the economic basis of power.” For tribal polities to exist, there must be some way of ensuring that such persons or interest groups cannot emerge and gain control. The ethnographic record suggests turning Marxism on its head. The danger is that some persons may be tempted to acquire highly valued objects by turning to production, potentially putting their social order in jeopardy. Although unwise to speculate in detail on the possible course of events, the drift is evident among the Tiv when circumstances oblige someone to convert brass rods into food and lose face at the expense of a strong-heart person. If persons could obtain wealth with produce or make it directly and use it in their ambitious social strivings, this would open the door to unequal economic relations and consequent overturning of the tribal political order. Some would inevitably work hard, cheat others, and by a series of unpredictable steps, secure control over some aspect of the production process in their exertions to turn out more wealth. Those who succeeded would subsequently find themselves able to extend some command over the subsistence requirements of others—making essential raw materials scarce by restricting access, limiting the supply of finished goods, or whatever. They would have a power base in the Marxist sense from which to expand some rule over others’ lives and possibly exploit them.

It is evident that tribal orders contrive to prevent some persons or groups from extending such hegemony over others by controlling access to resources necessary to meet their needs. It is not sufficient that people believe in equality to ensure such a political environment because there will always be those who, given the opportunity, would selfishly overturn the egalitarian order for their own gain. Challenges are an unavoidable consequence of the variation that typifies human behavior and understandings. This is evident currently at mine sites in Papua New Guinea where some people take all the royalties and live above their neighbors, and also in the endemic corruption among national politicians, leading

to considerable resentment and conflict. The current collapse of the state and breakdown in law and order in that country are partly the result of the reactions of stateless tribal orders to the imposition of hierarchies, and the emergence of some persons with authority and wealth who challenge egalitarian values unacceptably (Sillitoe 2000:219–38).

Spheres of exchange reflect cultural arrangements that thwart such concentration of power. The partition of the subsistence and social/ritual exchange domains is central to the political economy. Some tribal orders defend against any seeking to control resources and production by splitting production into two or more spheres. In this way, spheres of production mirror spheres of exchange. This effectively shuts off the wealth exchange sphere from production for subsistence. While the insulation is not absolute, the disjunction of the two holds overall. These conventions might be described as direct production, where households supply themselves with the essentials of subsistence, and indirect production, where people contrive to bring things into being within the sociopolitical domain.

This interpretation of spheres of exchange challenges the argument that they are an aspect of hierarchical relations. Hart (2005:165), for one, suggests that there are spheres of exchange in England, giving as an example that oranges cannot buy an Eton education, and arguing that such arrangements serve to maintain social classes. It also differs somewhat from that of Bloch and Parry (1989:14), who infer that “Tiv spheres of exchange buttressed a system of ‘gerontocratic’ authority” because young men were unable to convert the products of their labor into bridewealth, leaving elders controlling access to marriageable women in the “supreme” sphere. While Bloch and Parry focus on inequality where I focus on equality, these two points of view are not mutually exclusive. The radical difference between tribal and capitalist orders underlined here does not discount the possibility of domestic arrangements featuring hierarchy or exploitation. That is, equality between households does not rule out the possibility of hierarchical power relations within households.⁸ Furthermore, the institutionalized inequalities between households in capitalist societies are enduring, whereas the inequalities within African households based on age are transitory, as junior members can achieve elder status if they live long enough.

Individuals and groups seek to maximize social standing and esteem, a sense of social success and the limited influence that comes with it, by giving and receiving valuables in the exchanges that characterize social and ritual life. This is quite different from maximizing social standing and esteem through disproportionate ownership of material wealth—having power over others by controlling the resources they need to ensure their livelihoods, employing them to direct their labor, and taking an unfair proportion of the returns on their labor as profit. Capitalist economies oblige people to labor productively to earn

material rewards that bring prestige, status, and power, whereas tribal constitutions preclude such behavior.

The power disconnection is central to the polity, promoting the subsistence independence of households.⁹ The social order features political and ritual exchanges of wealth central to community relations, and a subsistence economy, crucial to the livelihoods of households, producing material necessities. Although there are connections between the two domains, they are effectively disassociated from one another such that subsistence production is largely insulated from wealth transaction where people compete for political status, and those who excel in wealth transactions cannot extend control over others' material needs. Where socially exchanged wealth features in everyday livelihoods and material well-being, such as canoes, it is hedged with community constraints. In short, there is no scope for individuals or groups to gain power over others through controlling access to resources that are necessary to their material well-being.

It is further significant for these social orders that people do not think to produce wealth systematically to exchange but, instead, transact for it. They depend on transaction, not production. Socially conditioned to regard transacting with valuables as giving them worth and earning respect, people would consider someone who spent a great deal of time producing them as eccentric and not worthy of high regard. It is the same with championship boxing belts. Aficionados may commission silversmiths to make exact replicas but, being obtained in the wrong way, these are of no value compared to the real thing, won in a boxing championship. It is what the belts symbolize that gives them value, not their material existence.

By definition, a tribal polity does not feature capitalist-like exploitation. It may even be distorting to seek exploitation in domestic arrangements, of the younger by the older or women by men, although as conceded above, the forestalling of inter-household inequality does not preclude exploitative relations intra-household, featuring gerontocracy or patriarchy. The vast literature on this, in respect of gender relations in the New Guinea Highlands, has some seeing these as exploitative and others arguing otherwise (Josephides 1985; Modjeska 1982, 1995; Strathern 1988). In this region, the obviation of inter-household exploitation intimated in the spheres of exchange arrangements extends I think to intra-household relations, and to argue otherwise is to confuse difference (evident in the sexual division of labor arrangements) with inequality. The relation between the sexes is central to the articulation of production with exchange (Sillitoe 1985, 2006), an argument extended here as a key to understanding the import of spheres of exchange. There is a mutual sexual-division-of-labor dependence that neutralizes anyone controlling production, or it even occurring to them. There are checks to prevent either partner becoming

too domineering, which give women a subtle control over the publicly dominant actions of men.

ATTRactions AND DANGERS OF CASH

Cash may mean something else to people on the periphery of the market economy than to those deeply in it.. A considerable amount of money currently circulates for example in the Southern Highlands Province of Papua New Guinea in pig and pork sales as people seek to acquire cash, but in a way that mimicks transformation payments rather than commercial transactions. Indeed, cash is well suited to serve as wealth acceptable in social and ritual exchanges in the sense that no one can manufacture it locally. Nonetheless, it is also the commercial token used in the materially affluent capitalist world and transferable for its esteemed manufactured goods, such as clothes, processed food, tools, and utensils. This is profoundly different to traditional wealth which, restricted to higher spheres, people infrequently used to purchase consumable material goods. The dangers of using cash in exchanges remain more latent than real so long as there are few or no opportunities to earn and spend cash locally, either by working for wages or cultivating cash crops, and with only a few poorly stocked trade stores accessible locally. Those who go off to find work in the Western Highlands often expend much of what they earn on staying alive and remit little home. The use of money parallels traditional wealth in these situations, in being nonproducibile locally and not featuring in everyday consumption.¹⁰

The distinction between special-purpose money and all-purpose money is relevant here, despite a reluctance to equate valuables such as bonito-hooks or shell armbands with money in any shape or form. Special-purpose money is only acceptable in certain transactional contexts and relates to the separation of spheres, whereas all-purpose money (i.e., cash) is acceptable in all transactions, which breaks the subsistence and exchange insulation. The absence of cash is significant as it makes it difficult readily to connect wealth with subsistence. Its existence allows the assignment of comparable values to a wide range of things including those necessary to livelihood, thus directly linking everything transacted, the antithesis of spheres of exchange. Bohannan (1955, 1959) comments that money, “the very nature of which is to standardize the exchangeability value of every item to a common scale,” will eventually “smash” the multicentric economy (Bohannan 1955:67, 70). Keynes (1982) foresaw this decades earlier in his discussion of the implications of the evolution of money in the ancient world, writing that “the gradual adaptation of the primitive economy of the tribes [migrants from northern Europe] to the individualistic capitalism which they found in Asia Minor” led to “revolutionary innovations” (Keynes 1982:253–54), namely the collapse of multiple standards of value.

People earning and spending cash readily breaks the insulation of production and material well-being from exchange and social well-being, and arguably effects more change than any other aspect of colonial or nation-state rule, by simultaneously undermining the reciprocal fabric of the tribal order and drawing people into the market economy (see also Bohannan and Dalton 1962:6, who talk of societies with exchange spheres as having multicentric economies that money turns into unicentric systems).

Some have criticized the argument that money undermines spheres of exchange as being too simplistic (Bloch and Parry 1989:12–16; Hart 2005:164), yet there is an irrefutable logic to the contention that money has a major impact on multicentric orders as discussed here. The danger is that money is treated as a fetish when it is only a component of the capitalist economy that facilitates the general exchange that undermines multiple value systems. Money alone clearly does not cause such change, rather it is an aspect of the new economic and political relations that affect these societies with connection to the market. Its arrival, together with the new economic relations that it augurs, serves to broach spheres of exchange. It is indisputable that if the members of self-sufficient households turn into money earners, this marks a major change in the local political economy. Consequently, people earn money through their labor and spend it on necessities and valued goods, and money so used makes spheres redundant. The shift in economic arrangements and the associated presence of cash are interrelated aspects of this process. In short, economic development, usually initiated in the colonial era and continuing today as part of the process of globalization, which features connection to the capitalist market with policies of trade liberalization, promotes the end of tribal orders. Unless, that is, people decide to ensure insulation by, for example, reinstituting some traditional wealth and declaring that alone as being acceptable in social and ritual exchanges. They appear to have done this in some regions of Papua New Guinea, such as the Massim where *vaygu*'a "wealth" remains the only acceptable medium in *kula*, and the Gazelle Peninsula where the Tolai continue to use coils of *tambu* shell wealth.¹¹

NOTES

1. Dorward (1976) argues that focusing on the subsistence economy, Bohannan overlooked the significance of craft activity and associated commerce, particularly of *tugudu* cloth, which he thinks the historical evidence shows was more widely exchanged than the spheres model allows. The significant colonial shock, he maintains, was the taxes that required people to obtain money to pay them. See Guyer (2004) for a further historical critique of spheres of exchange as applied in West Africa.
2. The complexity of the ethnography is further evident in the existence of slaves in a stateless society where people "grant political authority to no one" (Bohannan 1963:282).

3. Pospisil's (1963a, 1963b) insistence that cowrie shells function as all-purpose money in Kapauku society further makes interpretation of these spheres difficult, as according to the multicentric economy formulation, such a currency is incompatible with the existence of spheres of exchange. It suggests that he, like Barth who also identifies spheres of exchange in a society regularly using all-purpose money, has something different in mind than others who discuss multicentric economies.
4. Where classificatory sister exchange is the only legitimate way to marry and the exchange of wealth does not occur, we should not expect the spheres idea to apply to marriage, as it would imply thinking of women as objects.
5. People do not assess value on social grounds alone, there is a material hierarchy of wealth; e.g., a large pig is worth more than a small one. This variation in value also buttresses and stimulates the competitive side of exchange, further moving individuals to transact to the best of their abilities through rules stipulating which valuables are suitable for specific exchanges. On some occasions they must give pork, on others cash, or seashells, and so on (Sillitoe 1979:158).
6. Unless something unprecedented occurs to upset the established regime—such as the arrival of the outside world in the Highlands to supply more seashells than people could have imagined existed previously, as noted above, the consequences of which are still working themselves out, particularly the use of cash in transactions.
7. Strathern (1988:159) uses “transformation” somewhat differently in referring to spheres of exchange, to signify the switch from one sphere to another, resulting in the “creation of wealth items.” She also talks about things appearing “to be created by transactions, not by work”(Strathern 1988:163).
8. The presence of slaves in some Tiv households further evidences the existence of exploitative relations.
9. Subsistence independence alone, of course, is not sufficient to ensure freedom from domination by external political authorities or conquest by more powerful outsiders.
10. For Western Highlanders able to earn cash locally, the position is different. Strathern and Stewart (1999, 2000:45–46) give an informed historical account of the switch from shell wealth to cash in the Western Highlands (see also Strathern 1971:104–08 on the contribution of Australians in the 1930s to breaking exchange arrangements by paying shells for foodstuffs, and the account by Ru–Kundil in Stewart and Strathern 2002 for reasons people provide for giving up pearl shells).
11. I am grateful to Linus Digim'Rina of the University of Papua New Guinea, who participates in the kula, for confirming the position with respect to cash in kula exchanges. See Strathern (1978) for an early discussion of the enclavement of valuables in response to change, comparing the Hageners and the Tolai.

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